

Key to arrows

-  50,000–70,000 years ago
-  5000–1000 BC
-  1000–200 BC
-  200 BC – AD 1000

Early peoples sailed from New Guinea to the nearest islands, known as Melanesia. Over the next few thousand years they settled other islands. To the north they arrived in the region known today as Micronesia.

The early settlers sailed in outrigger canoes. Today, similar canoes are still used by islanders for fishing.

EARLY SETTLERS

The first settlers were the Aborigines, who arrived in Australia between 50,000 and 70,000 years ago, when the continent was still connected by a land bridge to New Guinea. The inhabitants of the Pacific Islands arrived next, when, about 7,000 years ago, people from Southeast Asia began to settle the islands. Parts of this region have been settled for little more than 1,000 years – the Maoris, for example, arrived in New Zealand in about 950.

Australia's history as a British colony is reflected in its flag, which features the British flag, the Commonwealth Star, and the Southern Cross constellation.



POPULATION TODAY
As a legacy of their colonial past, most people in New Zealand and Australia today are of British descent. In the last few decades, however, new settlers have arrived in the region from throughout the world. For more than three million Australians, English is not their first language. The various groups of migrants have brought their own customs, traditions, festivals, and food, making Australia and New Zealand multicultural societies.



Australia playing Pakistan in Test Match cricket.

SPORTS

In both Australia and New Zealand, sports have played an important role in creating a sense of national identity. Rugby is the national sport of New Zealand, while Australia's main sports are Australian Rules football, rugby, and cricket. Success in these sports is a great source of national pride.

ABORIGINAL RIGHTS

For many years, Aboriginal children in Australia and Maoris in New Zealand were taught only in English and were discouraged from learning their own languages. Today, the situation is very different. The Maori language is officially recognized in New Zealand, and in Australia schoolchildren learn about Aboriginal culture and traditions. But many people feel that the future also depends on reclaiming the land and resources taken from the original peoples when European settlers first arrived.

Today, Aborigines make up between 1 and 2 percent of Australia's population.



AUSTRALIA'S EXPORT MARKETS

1 Japan	18% of exports
2 US	10% of exports
3 South Korea	8% of exports
4 New Zealand	7% of exports
5 China	7% of exports

TRADING PARTNERS

Traditionally the UK was the main trading partner for both Australia and New Zealand. However, since the UK joined the European Union in 1973, Australia and New Zealand have had to look for new export markets. Both countries are now concentrating on the growing Asian market. In 1960, Asia accounted for only 25 percent of Australia's exports. Today over 60 percent of Australia's trade is with Asia, and Japan is its most important market.